

BACH CHURCH, ARNSTADT

Bach served as the organist in the Neue Kirche (New Church) in Arnstadt, Thuringia, in 1703–1707. It was renamed Johann-Sebastian-Bach-Kirche in his honor in 1935.

Weimar influences

The wider connections of a dukedom brought Bach into contact with current musical trends outside Germany, notably the work of Italian composer Antonio Vivaldi. It also spread Bach's reputation as a virtuoso. He was reportedly invited to Dresden to take part in a musical contest with French organist Louis Marchand; the Frenchman failed to turn up, implicitly conceding defeat. Although less constraining, and considerably better paid, than being a Thuringian church organist, Bach's position as a servant of the capricious duke of Weimar was never wholly comfortable. In 1717, he sought permission to accept the post of musical director at another German court, that of Prince Leopold of Köthen. Outraged by this disloyalty, the duke imprisoned Bach for a month, before reluctantly letting him go.

Prince Leopold was a keen amateur musician who maintained a small orchestra, and Köthen provided fertile ground for Bach's lively imagination. His focus shifted from organ music and cantatas to works for harpsichord, violin, and cello, and for the chamber orchestra.